Is there an emerging third prong in India's China policy in the form of an incipient external balancing effort, leading to another significant shift in India's policy on China? The evolution of India–US relations indicates a growing convergence in their views about the dynamics in the Indo-Pacific region. In January 2015, they issued a joint vision for the Asia Pacific and the Indian Ocean Region, in which they affirmed the importance of "safeguarding maritime security and ensuring freedom of navigation and over flight throughout the region, especially in the South China Sea" and proclaimed that their partnership "is indispensable to promoting peace, prosperity and stability in those regions."[105] These views were reiterated in the joint statement issued in June 2017, in which India and the United States referred to themselves as "responsible stewards in the Indo-Pacific region."[106]

In order to provide content to this vision, India and America have steadily deepened bilateral defence cooperation to achieve their common interests, which include the maintenance of peace, security, and stability, as well as the protection of the free flow of commerce through support for a rules-based order.[107] Accordingly, there has been a steady increase in both the number and content of joint military exercises to enable interoperability and even coordinated operations.[108] In addition, the two countries have concluded the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement to enhance the operational capacities of their militaries and a Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement to enable a greater degree of interoperability between their forces.[109] Bilateral defence trade has risen from USD 1 billion in 2008 to over $15 billion in 2017, and America has elevated India to the status of a "major defense partner."[110] India and the United States have also initiated the Defence Trade and Technology Initiative to transform their current buyer–seller relationship into a